moved on. I was lucky enough to have many peers who went out of their way to offer me solace and strength.

Perhaps the favourite part of my job was to sit through the civil society interactions to scribble down raw notes that would later be formulated into detailed press releases as the media had been strictly kept out of sensitive terrain (especially after the controversy around the interaction with a pastor, which had deliberately been misrepresented). The core purpose of these interactions was to create a safe listening zone for people who were fighting many battles against communalism, casteism, economic and food insecurity, lack of opportunities, etc. Rahul Gandhi was clear that these interactions were not meant to be used for political purposes, but instead to hear the people's problems. That is why it had been decided that these interactions were to be strictly recorded internally by the Congress and circulated later for public access. I also suspect that Rahul Gandhi, Digvijay Singh and Jairam Ramesh consciously used these interactions to mentor younger Congresspersons (while subtly positioning them in front of key people from each state). In fact, that is where I met this book's editor, Pushparaj, who was curating the sixty to seventy sitting and walking interactions in Maharashtra. Similarly, P.C. Vishnunath (Member of the Legislative Assembly) did the same work in Kerala. Likewise, even though I wasn't there, I know that Sasikanth Senthil (former IAS) did similar work in Karnataka, and Meenakshi Natarajan (former Member of Parliament) and Shobha Oza did so in Madhya Pradesh (while others did so in other states). From the two people I witnessed working in Kerala and Maharashtra (I'm sure various Congress leaders did so in every state), I know they reached out to every corner of their respective states for a couple of months before the Yatra and identified the right issues to bring to the leadership. I sometimes saw state leaders squirming uncomfortably because they did not want certain issues being raised to the national leadership. But the party leadership appreciated the call taken by these younger people.

The interactions themselves were heartfelt and enlightening. Rahul Gandhi charmed everyone with his knowledge and sincerity. And the many, many people who came felt very grateful that they could flag issues and